

The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-08-17

Source: *The Information* (daily editions received over the last 24 hours, cross-checked against theinformation.com). Prepared 07:20 GMT+8, Monday 17 August 2026.

Top Stories — What / Why / When / Which / How

1. Workday buyout talks revive hope the SaaS sell-off is over

- **What:** Silver Lake is in talks to acquire HR-software maker Workday. The report sent Workday shares up 19% on Thursday before they gave back nearly 4% on Friday, leaving the stock ~13% above its pre-report level. Workday is still down ~7% year-to-date but has rallied ~55% since late June.
- **Why:** A take-private of a marquee SaaS name would be a vote of confidence that the “AI-driven SaaSocalypse” — fears that AI lets customers cut or custom-build around seat-based software — may be ebbing. Workday is classic PE catnip: depressed stock but \$2.8bn of free cash flow in the year to January.
- **When:** Reports broke Thursday; the next big read-through is Salesforce earnings in ~2 weeks (consensus revenue +10% to ~\$11bn), with focus on AI-product growth.
- **Which (companies):** Workday, Silver Lake, Salesforce; analysts cited from KeyBanc (Jackson Ader) and UBS (Karl Keirstead).
- **How:** No purchase price was disclosed, so the buyout multiple — a key benchmark for other software LBOs — remains unknown. UBS notes many blue-chip customers “would like their spending with software company X, Y, Z to be down 30%,” a structural overhang PE buyers must underwrite.
- **Link:** [Workday Stock Jumps On Report of Silver Lake Takeover Talks — The Information](#)

2. Nvidia engineers ~\$100bn of financing for OpenAI’s Ohio data center

- **What:** Nvidia is nearing a deal to guarantee roughly \$100bn of financing for the first phase of a massive OpenAI data-center campus in Ohio, and is separately in talks to invest up to \$3bn in the IPO of SB Energy (the SoftBank unit developing the site).
- **Why:** It shows how Nvidia is using its balance sheet to pull forward customer demand for its chips while trying not to spook Wall Street over its own credit exposure.
- **When:** Reported over the weekend of 15–16 August; the \$100bn covers phase one only, with a second phase Nvidia could decide on in a couple of years.
- **Which (companies):** Nvidia, OpenAI, SoftBank, SB Energy — plus six large Wall Street firms in a related \$500bn financing partnership announced Monday.
- **How:** Nvidia wants to cap its credit exposure to the Ohio project at 25% of total financing (the same ceiling as the \$500bn Wall Street vehicle). SoftBank’s total commitment to OpenAI now exceeds \$64bn.

- **Links:** [Nvidia Nears Deal To Guarantee ~\\$100bn In Financing — The Information](#) · [Nvidia in Talks to Invest \\$3bn in SB Energy — The Information](#)

3. Neoclouds tout short-term GPU deals as AWS goes long

- **What:** Nebius and CoreWeave pitched investors on shorter-term rental contracts to capitalise on surging AI-compute prices amid a GPU crunch; shares of both moved sharply higher. Amazon Web Services took the opposite tack, stressing on its earnings call that it sells most AI capacity via five-year deals.
- **Why:** Two competing narratives on how to profit from the compute boom — neoclouds chase fat near-term margins on scarce GPUs; AWS argues long contracts de-risk the return on its enormous data-center capex.
- **When:** Pitches made this week; AWS's framing dates to its 30 July earnings call, after which Amazon stock rose ~11%.
- **Which (companies):** Nebius, CoreWeave, Amazon/AWS (CEO Andy Jassy).
- **How:** Short deals let neoclouds re-price capacity as GPU rents spike, but leave them exposed if prices normalise; AWS's five-year locks trade upside for revenue certainty on its build-out.
- **Link:** [Nebius and CoreWeave Tout Short-Term Cloud Deals, While AWS Goes Long — The Information](#)

4. Battery startups spy the exit from the “valley of death” — thanks to drones

- **What:** A wave of deals suggests next-gen battery startups may finally escape the funding “valley of death.” SES AI is pivoting from stalled EV programs to drone batteries, quintupling capacity in South Korea to 1 million Pentagon-compliant cells a year by October (enough for ~100,000 drones).
- **Why:** EV demand disappointed (GM, Honda and Hyundai all walked away from SES cells), but the Ukraine and Iran wars have turned drones — and AI-data-center backup power — into a fast-growing, higher-margin market for exotic battery chemistries.
- **When:** Deal flurry over the past two weeks; SES's drone capacity ramp targets October 2026.
- **Which (companies):** SES AI; Form Energy (\$750m raise), Base Power (\$1bn raise), Sila Nanotechnologies (\$1.4bn conditional Pentagon loan), Amprius Technologies (revenue guide up to \$140m from \$130m, gross margin 28% vs 25%).
- **How:** Demand is real but investors must recalibrate: drones, AI data centers and eventually robotics generate meaningful revenue but nowhere near EV-scale volumes. Only Amprius forecasts positive EBITDA this year; most peers remain pre-profit. SES expects ~\$30m of revenue in 2026.
- **Link:** [The Electric \(Steve LeVine\) — The Information](#)

5. Weekend feature: Anthropic's rise and Musk's flying roadster

- **What:** The Information's weekend “Big Read” profiled the ascendance of Anthropic's influential communications/policy chief (its “first lady”), alongside a report that Elon Musk's long-promised flying Tesla Roadster is finally ready, plus the usual pop-culture recommendations.

- **Why:** Colour on Anthropic's growing Washington and media clout matters as the AI-model race increasingly turns on policy positioning and narrative, not just benchmarks.
 - **When:** Weekend edition, 15 August 2026.
 - **Which (companies):** Anthropic, Tesla.
 - **How:** Feature/interview reporting rather than market-moving news — useful context on how AI leaders are managing influence and public image.
 - **Link:** [The Weekend by The Information](#)
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Overall Summary — Trend, Development & Sentiment

The through-line across the last 24 hours is **capital and confidence rotating back toward the “picks-and-shovels” and out-of-favour corners of tech**, even as the AI-infrastructure build-out keeps escalating in scale and financial engineering.

- **Trend:** Sentiment on software (SaaS) is tentatively improving — the Workday/Silver Lake report and a broader SaaS bounce hint that the AI-disruption panic may be over-discounted, though Friday's give-back shows conviction is fragile. Simultaneously, the AI-compute complex is red-hot (GPU scarcity, surging rental prices, ~\$100bn+ financing structures).
- **Development:** Nvidia is increasingly acting as financier-of-last-resort to its own customers, and the “neocloud” model is diverging from hyperscalers on contract duration and risk. Defense/drone demand is quietly reviving the battery-startup sector.
- **Sentiment:** Constructive but selective. Investors are rewarding both quick-margin (neoclouds) and revenue-certainty (AWS) narratives, and paying up for any credible path from zero to real commercial revenue (batteries).

Key questions & risks being asked and addressed

- **Is the SaaS sell-off really over?** Not settled. UBS clients still signal intent to cut software spend ~30% as AI enables custom builds; the Workday multiple is undisclosed, so the read-through for peers is unproven. Salesforce earnings in two weeks are the next test.
 - **Is Nvidia's vendor financing a strength or a systemic risk?** Nvidia is deliberately capping exposure at 25% and phasing commitments, but circular financing (Nvidia → OpenAI/SB Energy → Nvidia chips) raises concentration and credit-cycle risk that could pressure its stock and rating.
 - **Are short-term GPU deals durable margin or a top signal?** Neoclouds' fat margins depend on continued scarcity; a normalisation in GPU supply/pricing would hit them faster than AWS's locked five-year book.
 - **Have battery startups truly escaped the valley of death?** Demand is real but volumes are a fraction of the EV thesis; most names remain pre-profit and reliant on defense/government orders that can be lumpy and policy-dependent.
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Potential Investment Implications

(Companies named directly in the articles. For information only — not investment advice; figures are as reported by The Information and not independently verified.)

- **Workday (WDAY):** Take-private optionality plus strong FCF (\$2.8bn) offers downside support, but a failed/again-repriced deal or soft Salesforce read-through could unwind the ~13% event premium. Event-driven; watch the (undisclosed) multiple.
 - **Salesforce (CRM):** The next SaaS bellwether — AI-product growth on the upcoming print will set sector tone. A beat could validate the “SaaS bottom” thesis; a miss reopens the disruption discount.
 - **Nvidia (NVDA):** Financing muscle secures demand but adds credit/concentration risk; the 25% exposure cap is the key guardrail to monitor. Positive for chip-demand visibility, watch for balance-sheet-driven multiple compression.
 - **CoreWeave / Nebius:** High-beta ways to play GPU scarcity and rising compute prices; leveraged to the durability of short-term pricing — attractive on momentum, vulnerable to any supply normalisation.
 - **Amazon / AWS (AMZN):** Long-duration contracts trade upside for visibility; +11% since 30 July suggests the market rewards capex discipline. Lower-beta AI-infra exposure.
 - **SoftBank / SB Energy:** Deeply tied to OpenAI’s build-out (>\$64bn committed); an SB Energy IPO with Nvidia anchoring is a potential catalyst but concentrates risk on a single mega-project.
 - **Amprius (AMPX), SES AI (SES):** Defense/drone battery demand is the near-term revenue driver; Amprius nearest to profitability, SES a smaller, earlier revenue story (~\$30m 2026). Speculative, catalyst- and policy-dependent.
 - **Form Energy, Base Power, Sila Nanotechnologies (private):** Well-funded on new raises/loans; watch for follow-on rounds or eventual listings as read-throughs for the sector.
 - **Tesla (TSLA):** Roadster item is narrative colour, not a fundamental catalyst.
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